VIT Bhopal University

School of Computing Science and Engineering

# THE DIGITAL DIVIDE WITHIN

*From Basic Tools to Responsible Digital Citizenship*

A Case Study in Digital Literacy, Online Identity, Collaboration, and Cyber Awareness

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| **Course** | Digital Literacy (NGMC) CSE0001 |
| **Submission Deadline** | 31st March, 2026 |

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## SECTION A — ESTABLISHING THE CONTEXT

### A.1 What is this case actually about?

Okay so I went into this expecting it to be a fairly standard write-up. Use digital tools, yes. LinkedIn, yes. GitHub, yes. I have accounts on all of these. I figured this was going to be one of those assigments where you basically describe stuff you're already doing and call it done.

Then I read it properly. And its asking something I genuinely hadn't stopped to think about. Not 'do you use digital tools' but 'do you actually understand what happens when you do.' Those two questions sound similar but they're not, not at all. The first one I can answer with a confident yes. The second one made me go quite for a bit.

The case follows a student called Arjun. Second year, engineering, active on multiple platforms, looks like he's got it together. But the more you read, the more you see the gaps. His GitHub has incomplete and copied code. His LinkedIn has skills he's barely touched. He sends a two-line email to a faculty member requesting a recommendation urgently. He falls for a phishing scam even though he knew what phishing was. None of this makes him a bad student. It makes him a very normal one. And that's the uncomfortable part.

### A.2 How using something starts to feel like understanding it

Modern tools are almost too easy. That sounds like a weird complaint but stick with me. Canva gives you a hundred templates. GitHub lets you fork a repo in one click. LinkedIn has a wizard that builds your profile for you. You don't need to understand anything beneath the surface to produce something that looks good. And when the output looks good, it feels like competence.

I've made a Canva presentation that I was genuinley proud of. But if someone asked me about the copyright on the stock images I used, or why I chose that particular color scheme beyond 'it looked nice,' I would have nothing. The tool did the thinking and I took the credit. Thats the illusion this case study is talking about.

| Platform | What students typically do | What usually goes unexamined |
|---|---|---|
| Canva | Pick template, add text, export PDF | Image copyrights, colour theory, visual communication |
| GitHub | Fork, modify slightly, push publicly | Code originality, licensing, what the code actually does |
| LinkedIn | List skills, paste in certifications | Whether those skills are real and demonstrable |
| Google Docs | Collaborate on group work | Whether individual effort was honest or minimal |

### A.3 Being active online is not the same as being digitally literate

This is the actual point of the whole section, and I want to state it clearly because it took me a minute to really get it. Digital participation means you show up on platforms, you use tools, you're visible. Digital literacy means you understand what that presence means, what risks it carries, and how you're coming across to others. These are not the same thing.

Arjun is extremely active. He's not always literate in the second sense. His email to his professor is rushed and disrespectful not because he's a rude person but because his WhatsApp habitis took over. He falls for the internship scam not because he's clueless but because excitement overrode his analytical thinking. The gap between knowing and doing is the whole problem. And it's not a gap that closes just by using more apps.

## SECTION B — DIGITAL IDENTITY AND ETHICS

### B.1 Where I actually stand on this

The question this section poses: does building a digital presence on LinkedIn, GitHub and similar platforms genuinely benefit students, or does it quietly expose them to more risks than they realise?

My answer, honestly, is that it depends almost entirely on the reason you're doing it. If you're posting because you're genuinley learning something and want a record of that, these platforms are useful. If you're building a profile because there's social pressure to look competent before you actually are, you're basically writing yourself a cheque that your skills can't cash yet. And that debt does catch up.

### B.2 The equal opportunity argument, and why its only partly true

The argument goes like this. Before LinkedIn and GitHub, who you knew and where you studied were almost the only filters. A student from a smaller college in a smaller city had very little way to signal their actual ability to a recruiter in Bangalore or Hyderabad. These platforms changed that. Now a well-maintained GitHub with real projects can speak louder than a degree from an average institution. That's a genuinley good thing.

But here's where it breaks down. The platform can't verify anything. Anyone can list anything. So the person who is skilled at presenting themselves, at crafting a profile that looks polished, ends up competing just as favourably as someone doing actual solid work but presenting it poorly. It's not a level playing field. It just looks flat from a distance.

| What platforms promise | What actually happens in practice |
|---|---|
| Anyone can showcase real skills regardless of college | Anyone can also list fake ones, no verification exists |
| Work quality speaks for itself | Presentation quality often speaks louder |
| Levels the playing field across backgrounds | Early mistakes and exaggerations stay on record permanently |
| Connects students to opportunities directly | Also connects overconfident profiles to scrutiny they're not ready for |

### B.3 Why profiles become performances

There's a loop I've noticed among people in my batch. If more content on a profile gets more attention, students add more content, even if that content is inflated or not entirely accurate. The platform rewards volume and visibility. It can't reward honesty. So slowly, without anyone deciding to be dishonest, profiles drift towards being curated fictions.

It doesn't feel dishonest in the moment. It feels like everyone is doing it and you're just keeping up. But the cumulative effect is a digital ecosystem where professional profiles are increasingly unreliable as signals of actual ability.

### B.4 Is exaggerating just playing the game?

Some people say yes. 'Everyone does it. It's just how professional platforms work. You present your best self.' I find that argument pretty weak when you push on it a bit.

There's a real difference between presenting genuine strengths with confidence and claiming strengths you haven't developed. Listing 'machine learning' as a skill after following a couple of YouTube tutorials isn't self-promotion. Its creating a false impression that someone else might make a decision based on. If a recruiter offers you a role partly on the basis of that claim, you've put yourself in a situation you're not ready for, and potentially caused real problems for an actual team.

> *The casual normalisation of this — 'everyone does it so it's fine' — is how professional trust erodes over time. Not dramatically. Just slowly, claim by claim, profile by profile.*

| Honest and fine to post | Misleading, even if nobody calls it out |
|---|---|
| Actively learning Python, about 3 months in now | Proficient Python Developer |
| Practice project from a tutorial, clearly labelled | Original project listed with no context |
| Completed two MOOCs on data structures | Expert in Data Structures and Algorithms |
| Participated in one hackathon, didn't place | Award-winning hackathon participant |

### B.5 The permanence thing is not abstract, its very real

I think first year students, including honestly me until recently, treat digital permanance as a future problem. Like yes I know old posts stick around but that feels distant and hypothetical when you're in semester one trying to build a profile that looks decent.

The thing is, recruiters doing thorough checks don't just look at your latest activity. They look at patterns. Consistency between what you claim and what your visible work actually shows. Dates and timelines. The quality of your earliest contributions. That incomplete forked repo from your first semester is still there in four years. An honest record that shows real, visible growth over time is both more ethical and more impressive than a polished-looking profile that falls apart the moment someone asks a specific question about it.

## SECTION C — COLLABORATION vs. MISUSE

### C.1 Do collaborative tools actually improve learning?

Yes and no. I know that's a frustrating answer but I think it's the honest one.

Google Docs and shared platforms genuinely make group coordination easier. Working on the same document without emailing version 12b back and forth is objectivley better. Real-time editing, comment threads, revision history. These are good things. I've used them and they work.

But making collaboration easier is not the same as making learning better. In Arjun's group project, the tools worked perfectly. The document was produced efficiently. The submission looked polished. And when the faculty asked individual members to explain their sections, the gaps became immediately visible. The tools didn't cause that. The behaviour of the group did. But the tools made it very easy for the behaviour to stay hidden until too late.

### C.2 Where is the actual line?

I've thought about this a fair bit and I think the clearest test is this: can you explain and defend, in a five minute conversation, every part of the submission that has your name on it? Not vaguley describe it. Actually explain the reasoning. If you can't, you didn't really contribute to it, regardless of what the edit history shows.

Editing someone's paragraph is fine. Restructuring their argument is fine. Writing their entire section because it was faster and you wanted the group to do well is not collaboration. That's just covering for someone while giving both of you the same grade.

| Type of collaboration | What it looks like | Honest? |
|---|---|---|
| Everyone drafts their own section independently | Rough but genuine, thinking belongs to each person | Yes, clearly |
| Group reviews and strengthens each draft together | Ideas build on each other, everyone follows the logic | Yes |
| One person structures everything, others lightly edit | Unequal effort but some engagement present | Grey area |
| One person writes it all, others just submit their name | Academic dishonesty dressed up as teamwork | No |

### C.3 Why online accountability is harder to maintain

When group work happens in person, there's natural friction. If you're sitting in a room contributing nothing while others work, it's visible and uncomfortable. Online that discomfort mostly disappears. You can have a Google Doc open in another tab, make three minor edits, and appear as a contributer when you've done almost nothing substantive.

I'll be honest, I've been in group projects where this happened and I didn't say anything. Partly because calling it out felt awkward. Partly because the deadline was close and we just needed the work done. Reading this case made me think about those moments differntly. The person who coasted didn't just get marks they didn't earn. They also missed the actual learning.

### C.4 The best case for digital collaboration, and where I land

The strongest argument for these platforms: real jobs are built on this exact kind of collaboration. Asynchronous teamwork, shared documents, coordinating across distance without constant physical meetings. Students who develop these skills in college are genuinely more prepared for how professional work actually happens.

But it holds only when students are actually engaging. The solution isn't to take the tools away. It's to design assesments that require individual accountability alongside the group output. Short individual write-ups about the group's methodology. Brief verbal walkthroughs of specific contributions. Peer assesment with actual criteria. The tool is fine. The structures around it need to be better designed.

## SECTION D — CYBER AWARENESS AND RESPONSIBILITY

### D.1 The awareness paradox

This section surprised me the most while writing this report. The question it raises, how does someone fall for something they've been warned about, is one I thought I knew the answer to before I sat with it properly.

My initial response was: people who fall for phishing scams just weren't paying attention. Then I read Arjun's situation more carefully. He knew what phishing was. He could have described the warning signs if you'd asked him in class. He even hesistated for a moment before filling in the form. And he still did it.

The reason is that knowing something when you're calm is a completely different skill from applying it when you're excited or under pressure. Arjun wasn't sitting calmly when that email arrived. He'd been applying for internships and hoping for a response. When the email said 'you've been shortlisted,' his brain moved ahead of his judgement. Excitement and hope are powerful. They narrow your focus. They make verification feel like an obstacle rather than a reasonable step.

> *Scams are built specifically for this. They don't try to trick you when you're analytical. They wait for moments of emotional activation. Urgency, fear, opportunity, time pressure.*

| Red flag in the phishing email | Why it should have raised suspicion |
|---|---|
| Email domain very slightly altered | Official company emails only ever use verified domains |
| 'Respond in 12 hours or your slot is cancelled' | Urgency is a tool of manipulation, not a genuine requirement |
| Asked for login credentials to verify application | No legitimate employer needs your password for any reason |
| 'Dear Candidate' with no actual name used | Real recruiters use your name, pulled from your actual application |
| Embedded link doesn't match company's real website | Always hover over a link first to check the actual destination |

### D.2 Who is actually responsible when this happens?

I've gone back and forth on this and I think the honest answer is: both the user and the platform environment carry responsibility, just in different proportions and different types.

Arjun had been taught. He knew the warning signs. He felt doubt and moved past it. That's personal accountablity, and I don't think it's unfair to say so. At the same time, he was operating in a digital environment that consistently rewards fast responses, normalises urgency, and has trained users to click first and verify later. Attackers exploit exactly these trained behaviours. Putting 100% of the blame on Arjun while ignoring the structural conditions that made the attack easy is incomplete.

It's like blaming someone for slipping on a wet floor while also noting there was no warning sign. Both things are true. The person walked there. Someone else created and failed to mark the hazard. Accountability on both sides.

### D.3 Was it negligence, poor education, or something the system failed at?

Negligence implies someone ignored repeated, clear warnings and acted carelessly anyway. That's not quite what happened here. Arjun got some education about phishing in a classroom, probably in a low-stakes, informational format. Then he was put into a high-pressure environment, applying for opportunities he cared about, and the attack came at exactly the right emotional moment.

What he actually needed wasn't more facts about phishing. He needed pratice navigating that gap between knowing something and applying it under pressure. That kind of practice wasn't provided. So calling this purely his negligence misplaces the blame.

### D.4 What would actually work better than what we have now?

Current standard approach at most institutions: one awareness session during induction week, a poster somewhere, maybe a module in the LMS about password safety. These are not useless. But they address the knowledge layer while ignoring the behavioural one, which is where attacks actually succeed.

| What currently exists | What would be meaningfully more effective |
|---|---|
| Single induction session on cyber safety | Short repeated sessions spread across multiple semesters |
| List of phishing indicators to memorise | Simulated phishing exercises where students experience it safely |
| 'Never share your password' as a rule | Teaching why urgency itself is the manipulation, not just the content |
| General internet safety messaging | Regular practice: pause, check sender, verify through official channel, then act |

*Core principle: safe digital behaviour is a habit you build through repetition, not a fact you absorb from a single session.*

## SECTION E — COMMUNICATION AND DIGITAL ETIQUETTE

### E.1 Why do we write bad emails when we actually know better?

This section is maybe the most relatable part of the whole case study, which is also why it's a bit uncomfortable to write about.

Most of us have been shown, at some point, how to write a proper formal email. Subject line. Salutation with the person's name. Context for why you're writing. Polite, clear request. Proper closing. These are not secrets. And yet Arjun sent 'Hi sir, I need recommendations urgently. Send asap.' to a faculty member whose support he genuinely needed.

The reason is simple: habit overrides knowledge when you're moving fast. Arjun probably spends six or seven hours a day in WhatsApp conversations where short, direct, casual messages are completely normal. That register becomes automatic. Opening Gmail doesn't switch the mode. You write the way you always write, because it's faster and it's what your hands know how to do.

| What Arjun's email had | What was actually needed |
|---|---|
| No subject line at all | Subject: Request for Letter of Recommendation — [Name, Reg. No.] |
| 'Hi sir' as the opening | Dear Professor [Name], I hope this message finds you well. |
| No context, no introduction | Brief note identifying himself, the course, why he's reaching out |
| 'I need recommendations urgently. Send asap.' | Polite, specific request with context about the opportunity |
| No closing at all | Thank you sincerely for your time. Warm regards, [Name] |

### E.2 Is casual communication just becoming the standard now?

It's worth asking. A lot of modern workplaces are deliberately informal. First names everywhere, Slack over email, casual language in team communications. Is it outdated to expect students to write formally when even the professional world is moving away from formality?

The key distinction, I think, is this: informality works when both people have already agreed to it, when the relationship supports it. The problem isn't informality itself. It's assuming informality where the relationship hasn't established it yet. Arjun and his professor didn't have that kind of closeness. He imposed a casual register on someone who hadn't invited it. That's the actual mistake.

### E.3 Does the way you write genuinely affect how people see you?

Yes. More than most people realise until it's too late. In a professional context where nobody knows you yet, your email is often the first impression you make. Before any meeting. Before any conversation. Before anyone has heard you speak or seen your work. That message is all they have.

For Arjun the consequence was subtle. Not a flat rejection, but a cold, minimal response. Transactional. What could have been the start of a genuinley supportive professional relationship began on exactly the wrong foot. One email, one impression, and the tone of the whole interaction was set. These things are harder to undo than people think.